



# Kindergarten Learning Progression Executive function

## Validated version

Australian Council for Educational Research  
Prepared for Queensland Department of Education  
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# Kindergarten Learning Progression

## Executive function

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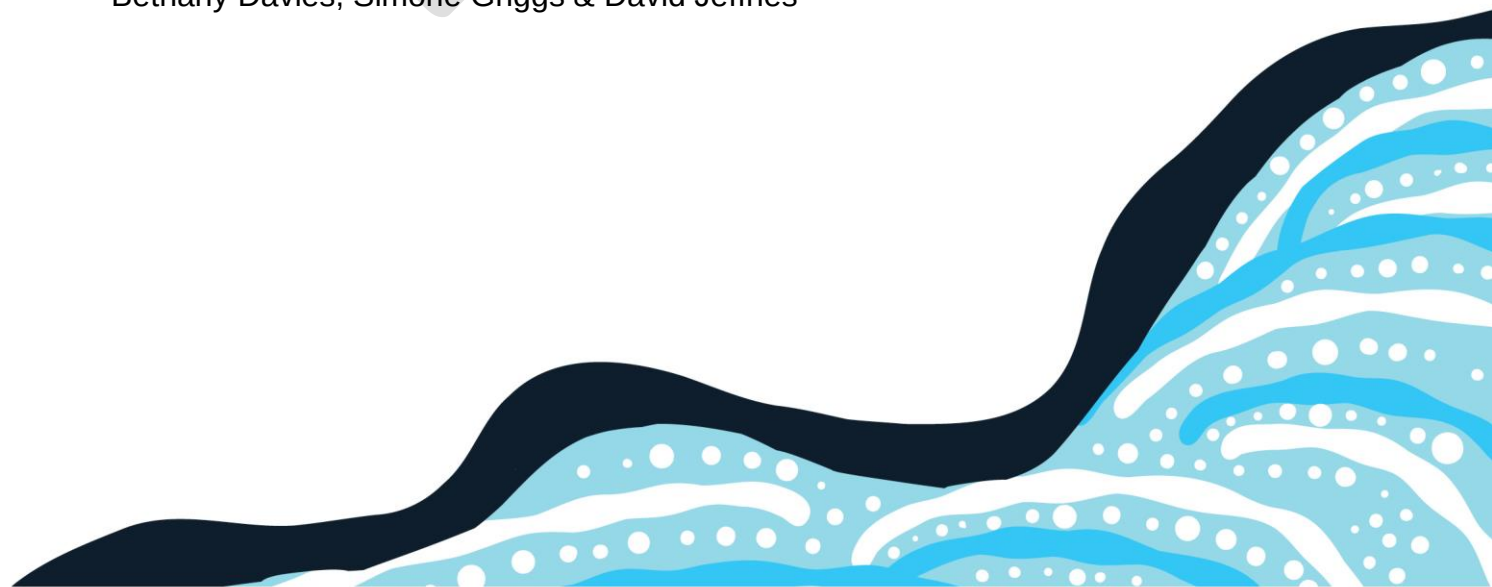
### Produced for

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### Project team

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## Observable changes in children’s learning and development

Links to QKLG: Identity, wellbeing, active learning

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| Persistence  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Observes tasks being performed by others, preparing to undertake one element of the task.</li><li>• Completes a single element of a highly structured tasks (e.g., finds their bag when they need to put their bag on their back).</li><li>• Demonstrates joint attention (e.g., in a group situation, can direct their attention on the same object when prompted).</li><li>• Requires assistance from others to stay engaged, (e.g., provision of simple, manageable tasks).</li><li>• Relies on routines, schedules and prompts to engage with activities and tasks effectively.</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Completes simple, routine tasks with one step instructions (e.g., putting their bag in their locker).</li><li>• Maintains focus despite minor distractions (e.g., staying on task, ignoring the sounds of peers playing nearby).</li><li>• Persists through small setbacks or challenges (e.g., when equipment is missing).</li><li>• Waits for their turn in a game with one other person or when asked to line-up for a short period.</li><li>• Requires reassurance with tasks that are new or challenging.</li><li>• Engages best when verbal and visual prompts are provided for a task.</li><li>• Requires instructions to be repeated.</li><li>• May not identify when they need help.</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Persists with tasks involving multiple steps that require some time, effort, and patience (e.g., building a block tower).</li><li>• Maintains focused attention when engaged in preferred tasks.</li><li>• Persists after an initial set-back but may require support if challenges continue (e.g., trying to put shoes on)</li><li>• Waits for their turn in a game involving two or three people (e.g., they are last in a line of children waiting and they do not express frustration verbally or physically).</li><li>• May show hesitance with new or challenging tasks.</li><li>• Aware of needing help but may not always ask for it.</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Persists with tasks involving more than three steps which require time, effort and patience (e.g., solving a multipiece puzzle, playing a game with several players).</li><li>• Resists distractions when focused on a new task (e.g., background noise, peers playing close-by, and lunch is being served).</li><li>• Attempts to manage set-backs and persist independently. May ask a peer or adult for help.</li><li>• Waits patiently for their turn when a game or task demands it (e.g., in a game of UNO if it is their turn next, but then order is reversed, so they now have to wait longer to have their turn).</li><li>• Seeks reassurance and responds appropriately to the feedback.</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Manages multiple different setbacks and distractions throughout complex tasks (tailored to the child’s ability).</li><li>• Supports others by providing strategies for managing setbacks.</li><li>• Actively congratulates others, recognizing their persistence, and helps or encourages them.</li><li>• Demonstrates patience and consideration when waiting for others to take their turn.</li><li>• Completes multi-step, goal-oriented tasks independently and successfully.</li></ul> |
| Adaptability | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Engages in routine tasks using familiar methods and strategies.</li><li>• Engages with new tasks or activities. May take time to feel confident with new tasks or activities.</li></ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Adapts when small changes are made to daily routines (e.g., a change to the order of activities).</li><li>• Adapts to a small change made midway through an activity or game, (e.g., when a peer suggests a different way to build the tower).</li><li>• Explores unfamiliar learning environments or materials.</li><li>• Participates in simple activities where thinking is required, and extensive practice and supportive clues are provided.</li><li>• Participates in tasks where trial and error are involved, with opportunities to experiment and try out a hypothesis.</li></ul>                                                                                                             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Adapts to major changes to daily routines (however, may still become slightly over-excited, or anxious).</li><li>• Adapts to a more complex change made mid-way through an activity or game (e.g., the game has changed from building an aeroplane with blocks to building a car).</li><li>• Explores unfamiliar learning environments or materials (may tend to focus on a few elements only or areas more in line with their interests).</li><li>• Participates in tasks where they can engage in trial and error, where solutions are not obvious, to experiment and try out a hypothesis with some guidance.</li></ul>                              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Adapts to major changes in daily routines without requiring support.</li><li>• Flexibly adapts to multiple changes throughout an activity or game.</li><li>• Thoroughly explores new contexts or materials, seeking opportunities to explore new environments and resources to extend their learning.</li><li>• Participates in tasks where they can engage in using higher order thinking skills, confidently experimenting and formulating their own hypothesis needing minimal guidance.</li></ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Demonstrates flexibility in response to their peers’ needs (e.g., invents rules to make the game easier or harder for different players).</li></ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |



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| <div>Problem solving</div> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Engages with simple problem-solving strategies with some adult support (e.g., finding a card, looking at a picture).</li><li>Focuses on the sensory aspects of a problem or task, rather than applying problem-solving strategies to identify the actual problem (e.g., notices that their clothes feel cold when wet but does not identify the need to change out of wet clothes).</li><li>May not independently identify simple, routine problems without adult guidance.</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Demonstrates predictable or familiar strategies for how a routine problem might be solved (e.g., what do we do if our drink bottle is empty?).</li><li>Attempts to experiment with new and unfamiliar materials, (e.g., incorporating unexpected elements into a process).</li><li>Shares how they attempted to solve a problem (may not reflect what actually happened).</li><li>Makes a simple plan (e.g., a role play of a familiar fairytale) that involves some collaboration or sequencing but is largely spontaneous.</li><li>Engages with aspects of an activity for sensory exploration or enjoyment, without necessarily seeking a solution (e.g., builds a block tower, enjoying the sound of it falling down and not viewing the ‘falling tower’ as a problem).</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Communicates 1-2 ideas for how a problem with unfamiliar materials might be solved (e.g., construction of a three-dimensional object using recycled materials).</li><li>Experiments with at least two different, familiar ways to solve a problem. (e.g., how to negotiate a play space with peers, but requires some hints and ideas to try more imaginative and potentially effective approaches from a teacher or educator).</li><li>Describes, with prompting, some aspects of how they attempted to solve a problem. When prompted they can communicate what worked or did not work, reflecting on what they did.</li><li>Independently plans and sequences an activity that happens within one day (e.g., putting on a simple play including assigning roles, simple costumes, and a basic plot) as well as adjusting to minor disruptions (e.g., a conflict between two children wanting the same costume).</li><li>Evaluates their own responses and may change their solution in response to feedback.</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Communicates several ideas for how an unfamiliar problem might be solved (e.g., how to dismantle a piece of unfamiliar equipment with spanners and screwdrivers).</li><li>Experiments with diverse and imaginative ways to solve an unfamiliar problem (e.g., incorporating new and unfamiliar resources into an activity).</li><li>Describes, without prompting, how they attempted to solve a problem providing some reasons for what they did, or did not do, why it worked or did not work and what they might do differently next time.</li><li>Independently or collaboratively plan and sequence an activity with peers that involves a series of steps to take place over two or more days (e.g., putting on an elaborate play with a detailed plot and consideration of how to engage the audience), including adjusting to disruptions and unanticipated events (e.g., rain during an outdoor scene in the play).</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Leads others through solutions to problems.</li><li>Provides a range of solutions for different purposes.</li><li>Provides solutions that challenge rules or understood ways of doing things.</li><li>Rewrites rules to games to increase their challenge.</li></ul> |
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